Swimmer Archie Goodburn Will Carry the Rugby Ball for Scotland

From: BBC Swimming Mined: 2026-10-23 3 min read

Archie Goodburn is a champion swimmer from Edinburgh, Scotland. Next month, he will carry the match ball onto the field for Scotland's rugby game against Australia at Murrayfield stadium. More than 60,000 fans will be there.

Goodburn is 25. He holds the Scottish record for the 50-metre **breaststroke** and has won a European bronze medal. In 2024, doctors found a rare brain **tumour**. After surgery, he returned to racing. He also **campaigns** for better treatment and more research for people with brain cancer. He has taken that campaign to Prime Minister Andy Burnham and to Scotland's First Minister, John Swinney.

At school, Goodburn played rugby as a **blindside flanker**. "This means the absolute world to me," he said. At age 12, he sang a **solo** for 10,000 people at the Edinburgh Military Tattoo. This crowd will be six times bigger. The match is on Sunday, November 15, and fans can donate to Brain **Tumour** Research and the Astro Brain **Tumour** Fund.

Word Treasure

breaststroke -- A swimming stroke where you pull both arms together and kick like a frog.

tumour -- A lump of cells growing in the body that should not be there; some can make a person very ill.

campaigns -- Works hard over time to persuade people or leaders to support a cause.

blindside flanker -- A rugby position on the side of the scrum where the player helps win the ball and tackles opponents.

solo -- A performance done by one person alone, such as singing by yourself.

Background you need

In rugby, an honoured guest sometimes carries the match ball onto the field before a big game, as a way of celebrating that person.

Murrayfield stadium in Edinburgh is the home ground of Scotland's national rugby team.

Charities often use big public moments like this to raise money and attention for the cause they support.

Break it down

WHO: Archie Goodburn, a 25-year-old champion swimmer from Edinburgh
WHAT: He will carry the match ball onto the field before Scotland's rugby game against Australia
WHERE: Murrayfield stadium, in his home city of Edinburgh
WHY: He is the guest of honour, and the moment supports charities fighting brain cancer

Why it matters

Goodburn shows that coming back from a serious illness can also become a way to help other people facing the same challenge.

Test what you remember

1. Where is Archie Goodburn from?

(A) Edinburgh, Scotland
(B) Dublin, Ireland
(C) London, England
(D) Cardiff, Wales

2. What will Goodburn carry onto the field before the rugby game?

(A) The match ball
(B) A pair of boots
(C) A trophy
(D) The team flag

3. Which swimming record does Goodburn hold?

(A) The Scottish record for the 50-metre breaststroke
(B) The British record for the 200-metre backstroke
(C) The world record for the 100-metre freestyle
(D) The European record for the 50-metre butterfly

4. What did doctors find in 2024?

(A) A rare brain tumour
(B) A heart problem
(C) A damaged knee
(D) A broken shoulder

5. Which rugby position did Goodburn play at school?

(A) Hooker
(B) Fly-half
(C) Fullback
(D) Blindside flanker

6. How many fans will watch at Murrayfield stadium?

(A) About 25,000
(B) More than 60,000
(C) More than 100,000
(D) About 10,000

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: A 4: A 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Archie Goodburn: Said carrying the match ball means the absolute world to him.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):